

A dream five decades in the making

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Jhulan Goswami

It is difficult to put my emotions into words. Since 1973, we have all been waiting for this moment. It took more than five decades, but I feel fortunate to have witnessed it in my lifetime.

When Harmanpreet [Kaur] took that catch, it took me back to 2022, when we narrowly missed a semifinal berth after losing to the same opponent, South Africa. I still remember how Harman caught Mignon du Preez at long-on that night, only for it to turn out that Deepti Sharma had overstepped. That no-ball hurt us deeply. Three years later, life came full circle for Harman, as her difficult catch sealed India's World Cup title.

After the 2022 World Cup, Harman and Smriti [Mandhana] walked up to me and promised they would do everything possible to win the next ODI World Cup. "We want to win it for you, Jhulu di," they said. On November 2, 2025, they kept their word.

This victory feels personal — not just for me, but for every player who came before this generation and laid the foundation. Those before us struggled immensely to stay afloat, and it was their passion and perseverance that allowed us to dream. This triumph belongs to them, too.

It was heartening to see the current players dedicate the trophy to the yesteryear cricketers, many of

whom were present at the D.Y. Patil Stadium to soak in the moment.

Playing at home, India was always among the favourites, but the journey was far from smooth. After a string of defeats, the team faced criticism and even questions about Harman's captaincy. That was unfortunate, as such backlash in the middle of a tournament could have hurt the team's morale. But Harman absorbed it, led from the front, and silenced her critics.

Despite the odds, the team never lost faith. They knew they were on the right path. Throughout the tournament, they fought till the end, and in the end, their persistence paid off. Having seen Harman and Smriti since their early years, it gives me immense joy to see how far they have come.

Over time, they have built a strong and united team. Under their influence, fitness standards have improved, and the culture of professionalism has deepened. Their dedication has enriched the dressing room.

Amol Muzumdar also deserves special credit. He took charge when things were unsettled after several coaching changes and brought much-needed stability. He created a positive environment and took responsibility for both wins and losses. Amol, Harman, and Smriti worked together to shape a

results-driven, confident side and that spirit sowed the seed for this success.

We came close twice before, in 2005 and 2017, but fell short. It would be unfair to compare eras, yet it is true that back then, we could not hold our nerve in the crucial moments. In 2017, we lost control in the final 10 overs. This group, though, handled pressure with remarkable composure and never stopped believing.

In our time, the challenges were different. Now, with the BCCI's full support, the women's game has grown stronger.

When Jay sir (Jay Shah) was secretary of the Board, he backed women's cricket wholeheartedly — from launching the Women's Premier League (WPL) to introducing parity in match fees. The results are now visible.

I genuinely believe the WPL has been a turning point for women's cricket in India. With this victory, the game will only grow. It will inspire young girls from smaller towns to dream bigger and strengthen the domestic structure further.

Before the World Cup began, I had promised myself I won't attend any of India's matches. But this team's performances made me break that promise, and I am glad I did. As Harman lifted the trophy, I couldn't hold back my tears. After years of toil, there were tears of joy.

As told to Shayan Acharya

